Pilot Study on

Evolution of Values among Children



By Monalisa Hota

Supported by Indian Social Institute

October 2012

Table *of* Contents

(*click the hyperlinked sections*)

- **Introduction**
- **Background and Justification**
- **Design of the Study**
- **Findings & Analysis**
- **Group-wise Analysis**
- **Evolution of Values through the age Groups**
- **Conclusion**
- **Issues & Concerns for Future Research**
- **Stories & Questions**
- **References & Acknowledgement**

Abstract

This pilot study attempted at understanding the thought process of children across ages 6 to 15 years around three broad value parameters namely, *Integrity, Empathy and Greed.* 37school going children, who had values as a taught subject, were interviewed using a set of 8 stories followed by questions to identify their thoughts and ability to reason in cases of moral dilemma. The findings not only reveal the lack of awareness of values among most children, more importantly they also reveal factors such as poor comprehension, vocabulary, communication, reasoning abilities, imagination knowledge and fear of punishment that may have an effect on internalisation of values. This was a very small study with no intention of generalising the findings. However, for those who are interested in producing value driven individuals, this study does raise some questions worth pursuing though a meticulously designed study in future.

1. Introduction

*"...required be*lie*fs cannot be hammered in; the needed attributes cannot be plastered on." ---John Dewey*

Is our education system investing enough resources on the character building of our children? Much time and effort is spent on mastering languages in schools; and an even larger amount of resources are spent on demanding subjects of mathematics and sciences. A belief that such knowledge would lead to a decent livelihood justifies the emphasis on these critical subjects; but then compared to them how critical is the 'value system' of an individual? Are we investing enough in producing individuals who are driven by 'constructive' values or are we just producing educated professionals with 'distorted' value system? For example, a doctor who is driven by the sole purpose of making profits and not driven by values (such as *empathy* and *Integrity*) would certainly be harmful to his patients. The same could apply to scores of other professions. In the present day, given that most households have limitations in terms of encouraging inquisitiveness, creativity and empathy, leaving the complex matter of value education to parents and society is not only risky but ultimately ineffectual. If children are the building blocks of a society, character is the foundation of human beings. Evolving from early years in childhood, character building requires independence of the mind coupled with guidance (not orders!) from adults. Some aspects of character that are valued for harmonious co-existence among human beings are *Integrity*, courage, inquisitiveness, *empathy*, justice, kindness, conscientiousness, solution orientation and so on.

Acquisition of the above values, especially *empathy* and justice, not only requires clarity of thoughts for their in-depth comprehension but also requires guided effort, skilful retrospection and meaningful discussions. A very prominent outcome of not taking this approach towards value education may be seen in our-day-to day interaction with well-qualified Engineers, Managers, Doctors, and other well educated professionals who find the task of empathising with others immensely challenging; thereby jeopardising their own levels of satisfaction and productivity. In addition, inability to take a morally or ethically appropriate decision has the potential to lead people into confusion, ignorance, denial and disharmony. If we wish our country to really develop, we need to act towards emphasising on producing value-driven individuals rather than

confused and dishonest professionals. How we chose and define the values for our children depends on the society we envision. We can agree to not create a society where leaders like Hitler commit crimes like Holocaust; neither do we want to produce and elect more leaders who would continue to fuel the current system of corruption. Such unfortunate fates are not only caused due to actions of some powerful people but also get aggravated due to lack of timely intervention by their members. As is aptly captured by the following famous quote "The darkest places in hell are reserved for those who maintain their neutrality in times of moral crisis" (Dante Alighieri). What this implies is that when people chose to be silent spectators in times of injustice, it begets more injustice, be it related to gender violence, caste violence or religious wars. Silence indeed does not prove to be golden in such times of moral crisis!

If we look around almost in any direction, we cannot help but notice the severe depletion of the core essential values from our entire system in one way or another, be it government, private, non-government, or even homes. This implies that lack of values is not sector specific anymore; neither is it driven by monetary motives alone; nor is the inability to act righteously determined by the number and quality of degrees one holds since we know that many people with limited education also act in accordance with values and vice versa. The inability to act righteously, however, harms the society so much so that it is now impossible to plan any welfare work without uprooting this menace. We, as people, speak too late and far too less to discourage the delinquents strongly enough. When the educated members of the society do not act to stop the 'wrong', they in turn create a breeding ground for more wrongful acts. It goes without saying that such an approach has caused immense suffering and destruction in every possible way, affecting each and every aspect of our culture and our society—solving this messy problem now is more complicated than ever before.

"[I]*f things go wrong under the Constitution, the reason will not be that we had a bad Constitution. What we will have to say is that Man is vile!*" ----B. R. Ambedkar

At the heart of this study lies the assumption that values evolve after the birth on an individual; and so the study attempts at mapping the course of their evolution in the present day. Understanding the value related thought process of children who are taught value education as part of their school curriculum would provide us with some information about the nature and nuances of evolution of values. It would then be possible to identify how well are the values ingrained in young minds and the factors

leading to their development or depletion. Debating over values is more complex than one can imagine as values do have multiple complex shades and cannot always be viewed in either black or white. However, this should not prevent from initiating the debate itself as neither are all values complicated nor do all situations demand complicated heated discussions. Whatever the case may be, an ever evolving human mind must be independent and reasonable enough to be able to perceive and discern the whites, the blacks and the greys.

As a pilot study, the scope of the study was limited to value parameters such as '*cheating*', *hard-work*', '*empathy*', '*greed*', 'equality', and 'stealing'. Geographically, only one school in Bangalore was chosen. Children aged 6 to 15 years were interviewed using a story based questionnaire and then for the purpose of analysis, grouped into three age-groups of 6-8, 9-12 and 13-15 years.

This report is divided into four broad sections, background and justification being the following Section. The Background Section is followed by the Findings, the Detailed Analysis and finally, the Conclusion Section.

↵ **Back to Table of Contents**

2. Background and Justification

"The prosperity of a country depends not on the abundance of its revenues, not on the strength of its fortifications, nor on the beauty of its public buildings; but on its cultivated citizens, in its men of education, enlightenment and character."

-Martin Luther King

Various studies have been carried out on evolution of moral values among children. The Moral Judgement of the Child based on Jean Piaget's research published in 1932 was first of its kind. He studied the moral development of small children through adolescence in the areas of *lying*, stealing, justice, punishment, cooperation etc. and established a sequence of stages that children followed as they evolved in moral reasoning and actions (1965, Piaget). Even though it was found to be lacking in several areas, this study went on to become the foundation for several other studies. For example, Kohlberg carried out a modified version of Piaget's moral development research and studied the phenomena in some 27 countries, including India, Kenya, Turkey etc. (Colby and Kohlberg, 1987) and established six stages that children follow as

they evolve in their moral reasoning. After several validation tests by other psychologists, Kohlberg's stages were found to be more robust and universally applicable (2011, McLeod).

Further to this, several other psychologists such as Erikson, Freud, Vygotsky, Eisenburg, Hoffman and Bandura have proposed many theories (2004, Cardwell and Flanagan) in the same area and highlighted the importance of culture, society, parenting styles, gender etc. towards shaping the moral character of a child. For example, Hoffman found that "the internalisation of an external norm occurs when a person feels an obligation to act in accord with the norm even in absence of concern about being caught and punished if they do otherwise" (Willard, 1997). According to Hoffman, certain parenting styles are negatively associated with *empathy* development. Discipline that focusses on how the action has affected another individual leads to stronger internalisation of *empathy*, punishment does not. His study on *empathy* is well supported and established that the ability to adopt another's perspective marks the onset of pro-social behaviour and leads to more compassion in people (McLeod).

On teaching methods, there have been several studies to identify the 'right' and 'wrong' approaches towards value education and have challenged some well-established notions of teaching through positive reinforcements or rewards. Interestingly, and much to the surprise of most, rewarding for being good has time and again shown to be detrimental towards promoting good behaviour; as also supported by several present day studies on motivation and human behaviour. This could be due to the shift of locus of motivation from internal to external stimulus, thereby affecting effective internalisation of values. In addition to the studies done in the past, there are many neuroscientists who are already working on identifying neurological factors responsible for ethical behaviour so as to eventually (ethics permitting) make humans ethical (audio: http://www.bbc.co.uk/radio/player/p00rdps3) .

The above background is to highlight only some of relevant work in various disciplines towards establishing useful correlation with phenomena affecting character building of children. The questions for us to answer are: a) do we value character building? b) If yes, in the present setting, are children able to internalise values? c) how far do the values taught at school "once a week" make their way into their behaviour and continue through adolescence and the rest of their lives?

We need to understand values of our country keeping in mind its diversities and complexities (which are rife with gender, caste and religious discrimination). Only then can we design appropriate interventions towards leading the young minds to a better future.

Aim: To identify the patterns of evolution of values in 6-15 year old students and draw comparisons among the general category students and the SC/ST/OBC category students.

Objectives:

- Identify the conceptual understanding of values across the ages.
- Identify the sources of values among various age groups.
- Identify the factors responsible for tolerance of 'wrong deeds' as perceived by older children (10 years onwards).
- Identify the extent to which the values are acted upon and under what circumstances do children compromise their values.
- To find feelings of guilt and indignation with respect to violation of value related conduct.
- Identify the ways children are rewarded or awarded with respect to values.
- To study differences for the above by gender.
- To study differences for the above by caste.

↵ **Back to Table of Contents**

3. Design of the Study

Methodology: To map thought process across ages, an ideal approach would have been a longitudinal research of the same set of children from childhood to adolescence. But that would be extremely resource intensive, especially time wise it would go on for 6-8 years. Therefore, the next appropriate approach of sampling children of different ages was adopted. Inspired by similar studies carried out in the past

(by Piaget, Kohlberg, Hoffman etc.), the researcher developed thematic short stories on moral dilemma. Two of the objectives of the study were also to assess gender discrimination and caste differences as perceived by children (to see at what stage they learn to differentiate on these lines), appropriate specific stories were developed. All sampled children were selected from the same school so as to control for at least one factor, i.e. the school environment.

Population: 6-15 year-old school going boys and girls from general and reserve categories who have exposure to moral science or value education as a taught subject at school.

Sample: First stage: Simple random selection of one section from each class; second stage: segregation/stratification of general and reserve category children; third stage: stratification by gender in each category; fourth stage: random selection of children from each category.

Sample Break-up:

Category of Children	**Group 1: Ages 6-8 years**	**Group 2: Ages 9-12 years**	**Group 3: Ages 13-15 years**	**TOTAL**
Female- General	2	4	5	**11**
Female- Reserve	1	4	3	**8**
Male- General	2	3	5	**10**
Male- Reserve	2	3	3	**8**
TOTAL	**7**	**14**	**16**	**37**

Data was collected from 37 school going students aged between 6 and 15 years. The school was a co-ed school and had 25% seats occupied by the reserved category students. The entire sample is divided into 3 parts based on ages, viz. 6-8; 9-12; and 13-15 years. In order to obtain data for gender and caste discrimination, gender and caste wise random sampling was done.

Geographical area: Piloted in a co-ed school in Bangalore City.

Method of data collection: The sampled respondents were interviewed through the medium of eight hypothetical yet realistic stories on moral dilemma followed by questions developed by the researcher, covering three value themes: *Integrity* (three stories), *empathy* (three stories) and *greed* (two stories). *Integrity* and *empathy* stories had one story on each sub-category: neutral, caste and gender while the '*greed*' stories were only neutral. In total, eight simple stories on moral dilemma followed by questions

were asked (inspired by Jean Piaget but modified to the Indian context, especially in terms of gender, caste and content). Direct questions to assess caste discrimination were also asked. The responses were voice-recorded and noted on paper/MS Word. Children were interviewed individually and all sampled children were told stories one at a time and then were made to repeat the story to confirm their grasp of all necessary details. The stories were repeated by the data collectors till the time children knew the story well. Children were told there were no wrong answers and were encouraged to share their thoughts freely or admit if they had nothing to say. Then, questions were asked one at a time in the same order. It took 50 min to 1 hour 15 minutes per child depending on age but almost all children enjoyed the process till the last story, and had appetite for more.

Type of data: Qualitative

Data Analysis: Manual analysis using MS Excel

↵ **Back to Table of Contents**

4. Finding and Analysis

The findings below are first divided into 'value themes' and each theme is then discussed for each age group. Before proceeding, you are requested to kindly read the stories to familiarise yourself with them. You will find a hyperlink there to bring you back to this section. Go to **Stories and Questions**

THEME: *Integrity* (values studied were '*hard-work*', '*cheating*', '*trust*')

GROUP-1 Total = 7 Children age 6-8 years [Break up: Females = 2 general and 1 reserve; Males= 2 general and 2 reserve]

Neutral Story: Key findings (Group 1)- **Story- *Integrity* - Neutral**

- *Cheating*: not perceived but act is wrong and right, both.
- *Empathy*: with Ashok and his friends
- *Trust*: not perceived
- Punishment: corporal
- Action orientation- No

The first group perceived Ashok's action as right as he was helping friends. Most perceived this act as 'not *cheating*', even though they had some idea that the teacher

would punish on finding out. Clearly, the *empathy* factor was with friends and not with their teacher ("he is *cheating* only a little": a 6 year old boy). None of them wanted the teacher to know (perhaps because she would perceive it as wrong and punish), with one exception who saw '*cheating* lazy friends' as wrong and preferred the teacher to know. The choice of punishment was corporal (beating/scolding/kneeling down) for all except one.

Gender Story: Key findings (Group 1)-**Story- *Integrity*- Gender**

- *Cheating*: perceived
- *Empathy*: with girl
- *Trust*: not perceived
- Punishment: corporal
- Action Orientation- yes
- Gender difference: no
- Reason for doing own work: evasion of punishment or teacher's command
- Punishment: Corporal (kneel, beat, stand with 'hands-up')

In the next question, Arun was perceived as *cheating* and five children opted for complaining, expect two children who would not complain due to threat. Those who opted for Sarika to complain could imagine well that the she should complain about the threat too or complain in Arun's absence. In this question, since the cheater did not do his work and was going to *lie* and had threatened the girl, he was perceived as a cheater. The reason for doing one's own work is either to evade punishment or 'because teacher says so', with one exception of a 7 year old reserve category boy who realised that it is for one's learning. There was no sign of gender difference at this stage.

Caste Story: Key findings (Group 1)- **Story- *Integrity*- Caste**

- *Empathy*: Somewhat, with Sunil (the poor boy) but had little idea about poverty
- *Hard-work* or fairness value: yes
- Caste: no concept
- Gender difference: Yes, in one question where girls see the poor boy's father as capable of action and boys do not.

- Action orientation: no
- Reasoning on choice of guilty and punished: poor

Almost all children empathised with the poor boy (Sunil) for the judgement but blamed the rich boy (Sudeep) for not working hard or the poor boy's parents for 'being poor' and not providing for their son. One blamed the teacher. Interestingly, for some reason, the guilty and the punished were different in most cases. Most respondents saw Sudeep as responsible but were punishing Sunil or the teacher or Sunil's parents for it. Similarly, some saw Sunil responsible but were punishing someone else. It is not clear whether this contradiction was due to lack of comprehension or dilemma. Neither was it clear why they perceived Sudeep to be responsible! There was poor understanding of poverty but there was value for *hard-work*. There was no concept of caste at this stage. Also, and this could mark a difference in perception based on gender: all girls perceived poor boy's father (who was sweeper in the school) to be capable of complaining while the boys did not. Action wise, only two children opted for someone to act.

GROUP 2 Total = 14 Children age 9-12 years [Break up: Females = 4 general and 4 reserve; Males= 3 general and 3 reserve]

Neutral Story: Key findings (Group 2)-

- *Cheating*: perceived by 8 children; Mostly girls from general category. No boy from reserve category perceived this as *cheating* the teacher.
- *Empathy*: with Ashok, his friends and/or teacher
- *Trust*: not perceived
- Punishment: corporal; except two children who opted for giving another chance
- Action orientation- Yes, about 8 children opted for someone or another telling the teacher.
- Reasoning abilities: Poor, mostly for reserve category children. Exceptions: 2 girls who were able to reason on the lines of *trust* as well as future implications for the 'lazy' children as a result of such behaviour.

Only 8 (6 girls, 2 boys) out of 14 children perceived the behaviour as wrong because of *cheating*. Most of these children were from general category. Most children

in reserved category (all boys and 2 girls) had no concept of *cheating*. Moreover, for most of them, the behaviour was either right as the cheater was helping friends or they were indecisive about the rightness of it (as they also lacked reasoning abilities for this question). The act was perceived as 'right' or as a minor mistake by the rest of the children. Of those 8 children who perceived the act as *cheating*, 6 believed in corporal punishment. However, 2 females in the higher ages exhibited maturity in perceiving 'withdrawal of responsibilities or *trust*' as ways to punish. Only two children (a boy and a girl) exhibited maturity in either giving a second chance or 'impositions' as reformative action towards the cheater. These two children were higher up in the age bracket and were more expressive and imaginative.

Clearly, in this story, girls have shown greater awareness and maturity in comprehending the entire situation from *cheating* to punishment. Reserve category children have fallen short of viewing the behaviour as *cheating* the teacher. However, many children who were unable to perceive *cheating* did perceive the act as wrong as the boy was helping lazy or non-*hard-work*ing friends; imp*lying* emphasis on *hard-work* but no concept of *trust*.

Gender Story: Key findings (Group 2)-

- *Cheating*: perceived by 8 children
- *Empathy*: with girl
- *Trust*: not perceived
- Punishment: corporal
- Action Orientation- yes, mostly
- Gender difference: no
- Reason for doing own work: evasion of punishment or teacher's command (9 children); to learn (4 girls and 1 boy)

None perceived the difference in any obvious manner. Of those who had perceived *cheating* in the previous question, one 11 year old boy from general category, who seemed imaginative, mature and empathetic in the previous story, appeared to be 'judgemental' and harsh towards the cheater in this story. His choice of words such as 'bad boy' and use of corporal punishment (as against impositions in the previous story) may be due to lack of imagination, *empathy* or reasoning in this case or due to

perceiving this act differently (of more serious nature) due to certain personal beliefs. Another 9 year old girl who exhibited the concept of *cheating* previously did not mention it in this case; however the act was perceived as wrong as 'he was not doing his homework himself'. Another boy who did not seem to have any concept of *cheating* previously, perceived this boy as *cheating*. Except the contradictory responses from three children, all other children were consistent in their responses with respect to the concept of *cheating*. In all, 8 children perceived the act as *cheating*, and therefore wrong. Except 4 girls and 1 boy, who realised that the purpose of doing own work is to learn, others perceived it as a task to be done to evade punishment or get rewarded. For one reason or another, 8 children opted to complain irrespective of the threat. Most children (9-10*) opted for corporal punishment (beating, scolding, hitting, slapping etc.). Some few also opted for dismissing the child from school or class. If punished, most agreed that the boy will change for better.

[* 9 or 10 is because they were asked to perceived punishment by the mother and the teacher perspective].

Caste Story: Key findings (Group 2)-

- *Empathy*: with Sunil (the poor boy)
- *Hard-work* or fairness value: yes
- Caste: no concept
- Caste based difference: yes, Most children who were unable to reason well were from reserved category.
- Action orientation: 2/3rd wanted action
- Reasoning on choice of guilty and punished: Good and consistent for half. Remaining were poor.

In the 3rd story, the teacher was perceived as guilty by half the children in this category. Except two of these children, most wanted the teacher to be punished (unlike the previous category where the guilty and punished were different). So, most children who perceived Sudeep as guilty wanted him punished. However, most children who perceived the rich or the parents as guilty seemed to be either lacking an understanding of poverty (could not empathise with the poor) or lacked an ability to express reasons

for their choice. One 10 year-old reserve category girl was unable to comprehend the story at all. Most children with lack of reasoning were from reserve category or were girls. Except one girl who had some idea about caste (but did not perceive it as affecting selection), none knew of castes. (As we will see later, most children had no concept of caste and those who claimed to know caste have actually mixed up religion, caste and sub-castes of Hindu religion under caste). Most children favoured action of some sort in favour of Sunil. Only 5 children perceived Sunil's father to be capable of action while most others either did not see him to be capable or were not sure. None were able to imagine why the teacher behaved that way (there was no answer to "from where did the teacher learn?").

GROUP 3 Total = 16 Children age 13-15 years [Break up: Females = 5 general and 3 reserve; Males= 5 general and 3 reserve]

Neutral Story: Key findings (Group 3)-

- *Cheating*: perceived by 10 children
- *Empathy*: varied: with Ashok, his friends and teacher
- *Trust*: factored in by few
- Punishment: Varied from corporal (5 children) to non-corporal
- Action orientation- yes, about 8 children opted for someone or another telling the teacher.
- Reasoning abilities: varied from mature to poor. While some exceptional children were able to empathise deeply with each character and reason keeping in mind the future of all, some lacked any ability to reason and most were just average in reasoning.

In this highest age group, 6 children did not perceive the act of Ashok as *cheating* his teacher. Of these, 4 perceived the behaviour as wrong due to being partial to friends or being un-helpful in the long run (but not as *cheating*). Interestingly, 2 males considered this action as right for helping friends despite empathising with the teacher and knowing well that the teacher would punish. One of them changed stand when probed, imp*lying* lack of reasoning. On the other hand, 10 children perceived this action as wrong due to *cheating* the teacher and breaking her *trust*. Some of them also

included both, *cheating* and 'not really helping friends', as reasons for wrong behaviour. Most children in this category had good communication and reasoning abilities and were able to support their stand well with reasons. All want the teacher to know despite the realisation that she would invariably punish on finding out. The responses to the nature of punishment were more varied and included a mix of corporal as well as non-corporal. 4 children opted for withdrawing *trust* but 5 opted for beating or kneeling down as a method to reform. The rest preferred suspension, scolding and explain/advising the boy.

Gender Story: Key findings (Group 3)-

- *Cheating*: perceived (11)
- *Empathy*: with girl
- *Trust*: not mentioned
- Punishment: non-corporal mostly
- Action Orientation- yes, 100%
- Gender difference: none
- Reason for doing own work: to learn
- Source of *cheating*: friends and others, mostly

Almost all children perceived learning or future success as motivation towards doing one's work. All 16 children wanted the girl to complain about the act and the threat. Most children who had no concept of *cheating* in the previous story, perceived this as a small mistake and still had no concept of *cheating* with an exception of one reserve category girl who viewed this act as *cheating*. On punishment, none of the children suggested corporal punishment in case of teacher and only 3 suggested mother would beat. 13 children blamed 'friends' and others as source of *cheating* while the rest blamed parents, background and other elders as possible sources.

Some interesting thoughts:

"…should not have given ice-cream because it finishes. Should have given something that lasts" reserve category female, 15 years.

"…work is equal. Everyone is given equal work…so they should do their bit. [if someone does not do their job] It's their loss." Reserve category female, 15 years.

"We should dare to do anything. Should only be afraid of parents and teachers and other things…but not friends." Reserve category male, 14 years.

Caste Story: Key findings (Group 3)-

- *Empathy*: with Sunil (the poor boy)
- *Hard-work* or fairness value: yes
- Caste: 4 children knew about caste
- Caste based difference: 4 children suspected caste as a cause (note that meaning of caste is mixed with religion for 2 of them)
- Action orientation: all except 1
- Reasoning on choice of guilty and punished: Good and consistent for all except one.

In the final story on *hard-work*, almost all children perceived the teacher to be at fault and were consistent in punishing the guilty. All empathised with the poor boy (as they valued *hard-work* and good performance). However, 3 of them chose to punish no one and 1 of the children (who was poor in comprehension and reasoning), chose to punish the poor boy for teacher's fault. 4 children in this group were sure of the effect of poor boy's caste on teacher's decision while most others had no idea about caste. Important thing to note here is that most children mixed caste with religion and other sub-castes. The concept of caste and its categories seemed to elude this group of children too, except 2 girls. Except one boy, all believed someone must do something to get the poor boy selected; half of them perceived the poor boy's father as capable of complaining or helping his son. Most children were good in communication and 'average' in reasoning.

THEME: Pro-Social Behaviour (Values studied: '*Empathy*', '*lying*', 'action orientation')

GROUP-1 Total = 7 Children age 6-8 years [Break up: Females = 2 general and 1 reserve; Males= 2 general and 2 reserve]

Neutral Story: Key findings (Group 1)- **Story- Pro-Social Behaviour- Neutral**

- *Empathy*: none, except 3
- Insult: 1 boy factored it in
- Action orientation: none
- Reason for behaviour: small age/ bad manners/ no idea.

Only 3 children showed complete *empathy* towards Anshu as they saw him/her 'get rejected' and 'ignored' despite spending the money and making an effort ('*hard-work* did not pay'). Rest had little or no *empathy*. Only 1 male (in reserve category) was able to see 'insult' as a factor of hurt. Most did not suggest any action for Monu; 2 attributed this behaviour to 'small age' and 2 attributed it to 'bad manners' and the rest had no idea.

Gender Story: Key findings (Group 1)- **Story- Pro-Social Behaviour- Gender**

- *Empathy*: yes, 100%
- Gender bias: no
- Punishment: corporal

100% respondents empathised with the girl and perceived the boy to be guilty. None assumed the teacher would have helped the boy since she was 'busy', thereby suggesting no gender bias. Punishment was corporal for everyone.

Caste Story: Key findings (Group 1)-**Story- Pro-Social Behaviour- Caste**

- *Empathy*: 4 empathised
- Stealing: always wrong for all
- Punishment: Varied
- Caste: no concept

4 children were empathetic; of these 3 would not complain immediately and 1 boy would complain immediately. The remaining 3 were un-empathetic and would complain immediately. They also wanted corporal punishment for the boy. All those who

empathised did not want the boy punished and wanted only advised/helped even though they believed stealing to be always wrong.

GROUP 2 Total = 14 Children age 9-12 years [Break up: Females = 4 general and 4 reserve; Males= 3 general and 3 reserve]

Neutral Story: Key findings (Group 2)-

- *Empathy*: all empathised except 2
- Insult: 1 boy factored it in
- Action orientation:
- Reason for rudeness: varied from 'no idea' to sibling rivalry (only for few older children with better reasoning)

In this category, 2 children were totally un-empathetic for Anshu (as they said "Anshu's feelings were not hurt at all). Two children who empathised partially were also able to perceive the factor of 'insult' as a cause of hurt but they did not know the words 'feelings' or 'hurt'. The remaining 10 children were empathetic and those in the higher ages perceived 'insult' factor into their reasoning. Most children 10 years and older had matured reasoning as they were able to attribute the cause of rudeness to sibling rivalry and younger age and dislike for the brother. Most children who empathised suggested Monu to 'act' in one way or another.

Gender Story: Key findings (Group 2)-

- *Empathy*: All except 1
- Gender bias: no
- Punishment: corporal and non-corporal

All but one respondent empathised with the girl and perceived the boy to be guilty. 13 children said that the teacher would not helped boy either since she was 'busy', thereby suggesting no gender bias. Only one girl said that the teacher would help the boy as he was 'big'. The choice of reformative action for this age group was a mix of corporal and non-corporal; most children however chose non-corporal ways

(such as impositions, reciprocation of similar behaviour, and dismissal). 3 children did opt for no punishment too.

Caste Story: Key findings (Group 2)-

- *Empathy*: 2/3rd empathised with the poor boy; some empathised with those whose food was stolen
- Stealing: always wrong to steal or right for poor/hungry to steal.
- Punishment: corporal as well as non-corporal
- Caste: no concept

Most of the children perceived the act as wrong. Some of them (9) perceived it as wrong but were able to empathise with the poor and hungry boy. 7 of them chose never or not to complain immediately to authorities and help him; but 2 of these opted for complaining immediately (as they also empathised with the children who would remain hungry as a result). 3 children perceived the act as absolutely wrong without being able to empathise with the poor boy, they opted for complaining immediately. Interestingly, 2 children perceived the act as right, as poor and hungry can steal; of these, 1 (boy) opted for complaining immediately (he was unable to reason this decision) while the girl chose never to complain. As for reformative action, a mix of corporal and non-corporal were suggested while many chose not to punish and advice/help instead.

GROUP 3 Total = 16 Children age 13-15 years [Break up: Females = 5 general and 3 reserve; Males= 5 general and 3 reserve]

Neutral Story: Key findings (Group 3)-

- *Empathy*: mostly with Anshu in varying degrees, with some exceptions
- Insult: mostly factored in
- Action orientation: mostly yes
- Reason for rudeness: distraction/ small age/ apathy

Most children were empathetic in different degrees and realised that Monu was guilty of hurting and insulting Anshu before others, with an exception of a few who

could not empathise with Anshu. However, there was lack of reasoning and depth in understanding of the situation. Very few girls and boys were able to see reasons such as general apathy or the inter-personal aspect of their relation as a factor responsible for that kind of behaviour while most attributed it to age or distraction. The most unusual response was from a boy (from reserved category) who perceived loss of money as the only reason for hurt. Most others suggested that Monu must apologise or accept the gift or console.

Gender Story: Key findings (Group 3)-

- *Empathy*: All except 1
- Gender bias: 1 reserve category boy
- Punishment: corporal and non-corporal

In the second story, all respondents except 1 held Raghav guilty and wanted him punished one way or another. The one who differed perceived teacher as guilty but refrained from acting against the teacher (as "teachers cannot be punished"). Reformative choices were a mix of corporal and non-corporal. On gender discrimination, only one reserve category boy (the one who perceived money as a factor in the previous story) indicated that the teacher would be partial to males, hinting at gender discrimination.

Caste Story: Key findings (Group 3)-

- *Empathy*: 2/3rd empathised with the poor boy; some empathised with those whose food was stolen
- Stealing: always wrong (2/3rd) to steal or right for poor/hungry to steal (1/3rd).
- Punishment: non-corporal
- Caste: no concept

Most children were able to empathise with the poor boy's situation and would not complain immediately. All but one perceived stealing as wrong but preferred helping and advising him instead of punishing. 2 girls also perceived the act as 'right' since the situation justified it but one of them opted for complaining and punishing while the other (older) preferred subtle ways to reform. About 5 children (almost 1/3rd) were

unable to empathise fully or did not empathise at all and preferred complaining immediately. Only 1/3rd of children were able to see stealing as a minor mistake or a rather acceptable act in case of hunger and poverty. Most others believed it to be totally unacceptable at all times, irrespective of the situation. However, most of these children expressed kindness and *empathy* for the poor boy, thereby suggesting that stealing may be acceptable in certain situations. When asked 'how would the poor boy feel when his friend complained', only one child said 'betrayed'. The rest were either clueless or simply said 'bad'. None in this age and for this story suggested corporal punishment.

THEME: *Greed* **Stories- *Greed***

GROUP-1 Total = 7 Children ages 6-8 years [Break up: Females = 2 general and 1 reserve; Males= 2 general and 2 reserve]

Key findings-

- Concept of *greed*- No
- Elders always truthful- Yes
- Math word problem comprehension- none

There was no concept of *greed* among these children on either question. All '*trust*ed the aunt' as they perceived elders to be always truthful. In both stories, the children were perceived guilty of *lying*. An unrelated yet important point was that none of the children were able to figure out '80' for remaining chocolates.

GROUP 2 Total = 14 Children age 9-12 years [Break up: Females = 4 general and 4 reserve; Males= 3 general and 3 reserve]

Key findings-

- Concept of *greed*- mostly no (10); poor reasoning/explanation (3); 1 knew well.
- Elders always truthful- yes
- Math word problem comprehension- 5 solved

Even in this age group, most (10) children had no concept of *greed*. 3 children showed some awareness and indicated that *greed* is always bad. However, since they were poor in reasoning and explanation, it was not clear if they really knew the meaning well. *Greed* was confused with stealing, *lying*, being rude etc. Only 1 girl (from reserve category) knew the meaning of greedy and believed it to be 'always bad'. Even though this group came across as more imaginative than the previous one, none were able to imagine or reason why the boy could be saving more money when his parents fulfilled all his demands. Most still believed that he wanted to buy something or do something good (like charity or gift for parents). Like in the previous stage, elders were thought of as always truthful. Only 5 children were able to calculate the chocolates remaining numbers of chocolates (80).

GROUP 3 Total = 16 Children age 13-15 years [Break up: Females = 5 general and 3 reserve; Males= 5 general and 3 reserve]

Key findings-

- Concept of *greed*- 1/3rd did not have any concept of *greed*; 1/3rd seemed ambiguous; 1/3rd knew well.
- Elders always truthful- mostly yes (except 3)
- Math word problem comprehension- missing data

A third of children in this category had no concept of *greed* and 1/3rd appeared confused, although they exhibited a little superior reasoning abilities in both stories. Only some knew the meaning of greedy very well and thought of it as always 'bad'. Only 3 children indicated that elders may *lie* and the rest believed elders to be truthful at all times.

↵ **Back to Table of Contents**

5. Group-wise Analysis:

Group 1 (6-8 years)

Comprehension, communication, imagination and reasoning abilities determined how the children responded to the stories told to them. For most children in this group, it required numerous repetitions and intervention from the interviewers' end to make the stories 'understood', although all efforts were made to not be suggestive. These abilities were limited in most children with an exception of two boys.

Their ability to empathise also depended on their ability to understand the story well. After ensuring that the stories were comprehended well, the interviewers proceeded with the questions. It was found that most children were able to empathise but only partially. *Empathy* also varied with stories; while in Raghav's story, all empathised with the girl, in Anshu's story, only 3 empathised with Anshu. Similarly, in Sunil's story, all empathised with Sunil as he was *hard-work*ing but most were unable to empathise with his poverty ridden situation or with Sudeep (as they held him guilty for selection). However, many were able to empathise with Anil and wanted to help and advice instead of punishing him. There was a twist in Sunil's story where the guilty and the punished were mostly different (e.g. Sudeep perceived as guilty but poor's parents punished…). Sudeep was seen as guilty by many children. Sunil and his parents too were perceived to be guilty by some; were blamed for their own poverty. They were unable to reason for these decisions. These responses indicate that *empathy* was partial and reasoning was poor.

Most children valued *hard-work* the most in all the stories that mentioned this quality. Laziness and *cheating* was, in general, perceived as 'wrong'. However, it was not as straight forward. Cheaters were not always seen as wrong and not always punished. For example, Ashok was engaged in wrong behaviour but most did not perceive him as guilty of *cheating* the teacher whereas Arun too was engaged in wrong behaviour but he was judged to be wrong and punished. Note that Arun returned the favour of his friend (which could mean bribe or pay-back) but this detail was never registered by anyone. In both the stories, there were lazy children who were not doing their work and were benefitting but in the first story there was no mention of punishing the 'lazy' or the cheater while in the second, there was punishment for both these reasons. It may be seen as imp*lying* that *cheating* is acceptable if one is *hard-work*ing and likable but not

when one is lazy and 'bad boy'? If this behaviour continues, then….'good' people who do wrong would get away but the 'bad' who do wrong always get punished! Action orientation supports this assumption where Ashok's behaviour was condoned while Arun's was always acted against. At this stage, punishment was all corporal (kneeling, beating, etc.) and work was motivated by either evasion of punishment or unquestionable demand from authorities.

None had any idea about *greed* or caste and all perceived elders to be always right and truthful. As for gender, there was no visible difference in reasoning or thoughts except in the case of perceiving the father of the poor boy Sunil as capable of action: 2 out of 3 girls perceived him capable.

Due to small sample size, young age, and lack of similar data, children in this group cannot be compared to any pre-established age specific standards. Instead, for this pilot, they will be considered as the point of reference for the older children.

Group 2 (9-12 years)

Again, to ensure comprehension, communication, imagination and reasoning the stories were told in a manner to facilitate the above. For most children in this group, it required relatively fewer repetitions and intervention from the interviewers' end to make the stories understood well.

Degree of *empathy* varied with stories form character to character. With age, more and more children were able to empathise. The simple story of Raghav was a clear case of *empathy* generation for the girl. However, there was much deeper connection and more *empathy* in the group as seen in stories of Anshu, Sunil and Anil. In Anshu's story, few exceptional children were able to imagine 'sibling rivalry' or 'distraction' for Monu's rudeness. In case of Anil, there were extreme responses on the act of stealing, with 2 children perceiving it as right when one is poor and hungry while 3 perceived it as absolutely wrong and therefore suggested immediate punishment for the 'thief'. As for the rest, most were empathetic, like the previous group and wanted to help the boy even though they perceived stealing as a wrongful act. Similarly, in the case of Sunil, the confusion from the previous stage had disappeared and children were now punishing the guilty; and half of the children perceived the teacher to be responsible thereby reaffirming their statements on favouring equality. There was maturity in the sense of

perceiving an adult or an authority figure to be wrong and punishable. Some children however, continued to lack *empathy* as they perceived Sudeep to be guilty without any stated reason. Only 2 children were able to analyse the 'rightness' of stealing based on circumstances while most stated it to be always 'wrong', despite suggesting actions that favoured the poor boy.

Similar to the previous group, the value *hard-work* was emphasised by this group as well. Similarly, laziness and *cheating* was, in general, perceived as 'wrong'. Considering that more than half the children perceived the acts of Arun and Ashok as *cheating*, it showed some consistency in reasoning. However, there were some inconsistencies too. There were 2 children who reported *cheating* for only one of the cases and perceived the other as non-*cheating*. More girls than boys were seen as perceiving the acts as *cheating* and no boy from the reserve category perceived *cheating* in this age group. Also, reasoning, empathising and communication abilities of the reserve category children were found to be poor. It must be noted that still 7 children, i.e. half of the group was unable to perceive *cheating* and give reasons for the same. Most perceived the acts as wrong but not as *cheating* or breaking someone's *trust* or deceiving someone who *trust*ed them. None of them brought in the angle of *trust* in the matter of *cheating* the teacher. The aspect of *cheating* adds a dimension to the story and tries to capture the ability of the child to comprehend, imagine and empathise with the characters.

At this stage, punishment was mostly corporal (kneeling, beating, etc.) but a shift towards non-corporal was seen in some. Work was motivated by either evasion of punishment or reward with the exception of 4 girls and 1 boy. 9 children were still learning out of fear and anticipation of reward imp*lying* that in the absence of external motivating factors such as punishment or reward, no work may get done by these children. Many studies have established that inappropriate rewarding techniques interfere negatively with internal motivation and shifts focus to external motivation. Action orientation depended on the guilty but many favoured action over inaction compared to the previous stage.

Most had no idea about *greed* or caste; but 4 indicated some knowledge of it. Due to their poor explanation and reasoning, their stand was not clear. On caste, a difference was noted with respect to *cheating* wherein none of the reserve category boys perceived *cheating*. In general, comprehension was found to be poor for reserved

category children. As for gender, there was no suggested bias felt by any respondent. But more girls came across as better communicators, reasonable, imaginative and empathetic than their male counterparts. All perceived elders to be always right and truthful, indicating the extent to which young minds question their surroundings, especially the adults around them. Surprisingly, only 5 children were able to solve the simple math problem (100-80) for the last question.

Group 3 (13-15 years)

Most children in this group were able to comprehend stories instantly. Surprisingly, some intervention was still needed in certain cases that lacked concentration and vocabulary. Contrastingly, there were some children who were expressive and strong in communication (but it must be noted that most of such children joined this school only a few years ago).

Just like Group 2, degree of *empathy* varied with stories form character to character but as should be, this group was found to have relatively better depth. More children were able to attribute Monu's rude behaviour to reasons other than age, such as rivalry, nature, dislike, apathy etc. They were also able to relate the cause of hurt with public insult, unlike in other stages. Even in Sunil's story, teacher was held responsible and punished, emphasising on equality and fairness. Although, they were unable to imagine the cause of teacher's decision. Anil's story was the most interesting wherein most children empathised with Anil but surprisingly, 5 (1/3rd) children still fail to do so. These children were not able to distinguish intention from action and believed in instant punishment to reform. On the other hand, most empathisers believed that stealing was wrong however they followed a reasonable path while acting by choosing to advice and not punish Anil. This indicates that they were able to separate action from intention even though they contradicted this when asked directly whether stealing is ever 'right'. For some reason, none noticed the third character named Saurabh in the second story. This may require further exploration as much younger children noticed Saurabh's presence and were able to use him in action during pre-piloting. It was observed that none were able to perceive the difficulty associated with 'asking' for food, suggesting scope of development of deeper *empathy*. 1/3rd of these children were unable to empathise.

Valuing *hard-work* remained intact at this stage but proportionally, same number of children perceived *cheating* in both stories. 2 children who perceived Ashok to be not *cheating* believed that he was being partial and that was wrong (a new reason). Also, 'breaking *trust* of the teacher' was perceived as a (new) reason for wrong act as well. Some exceptional children were also conscious of the fact that helping lazy children is harmful for their future as they would not learn anything. Therefore, for the sake of every one's learning, one must take action. Most of the children indicated learning as a motivation for working. It must be noted here that nearly the same proportion of children perceived *cheating* as previously, indicating no improvement from previous stage. Action orientation depended on the guilty but many favoured action over inaction like the previous stage.

Since reasoning was better developed in this stage, punishment styles were also different such as corporal, reciprocal, no punishment, only advice, impositions, suspensions, etc. Most believed in non-corporal punishment.

Only a third of children knew what *greed* meant and considered it to always 'bad'. Among the others, half had some knowledge and half had none. Hardly anyone knew the exact meaning of caste and those who claimed to know actually had mixed caste and religion together. As for gender, there was no suggested bias felt by any respondent except 1 boy who indicated both gender and caste bias in Raghav's and Sunil's story respectively. More girls came across as better communicators, reasonable, imaginative and empathetic than their male counterparts. There was no perceived difference or discrimination related ideas. Except 3 children, the rest still perceived elders to be always right and truthful.

6. Evolution of Values through the age groups:

Since this study was strictly qualitative in nature, it would not be possible to mark evolution quantitatively for most part at this stage. This is an area to work on, if this study gets scaled up. However, based on the above analysis, some patterns can be highlighted. This study involved values such as *hard-work*, *cheating*, *empathy*, *greed*, gender discrimination, stealing, action-orientation, caste discrimination. The results not only show findings around these areas but also reveal some other essential under*lying* factors. All the relevant factors are listed below:

1. **Comprehension** was poor for 1st Group but it improved consistently. However, the **ability to imagine and reason** was weak for most children; these improved drastically from 1st to 2nd group and only slightly for the 3rd group. There were still a large number of children in the 2nd group who needed constant intervention to facilitate comprehension.
2. In this **English medium** School, majority children were poor in basic English vocabulary and **grammar**.
3. Related to the above is the ability to express emotions or situations using variety of words. This too was very poor.
4. Ability to **empathise** only got better but the degree of improvement was more from 1st to 2nd than from 2nd to 3rd group. In the 3rd group, even though more children were able to perceive '*trust*', 'apathy' and 'insult' factors, many were unable to empathise with poverty and stealing caused by hunger. Between the 2nd and 3rd group, the latter exhibited deeper *empathy*. Even upto the 3rd stage, children assumed adults to be always truthful, imp*lying* lack of questioning attitude.
5. A clear act of ***cheating*** was not perceived as *cheating* by many. Perception of *cheating* improved only from group 1st to 2nd and remained constant for the 3rd group. ***Hard-work*** and **fairness** was consistently emphasised by all in all ages. Although, many children up to the 2nd group stated **punishment or reward** as a reason to do their work unlike the older ones who stated **learning and success** as the motivation behind working hard. Many older children were able to realise drawbacks of being 'lazy'.
6. With age, choice of **punishment** shifted to non-corporal. It may not be conclusive at this stage but most children who chose non-corporal punishment were also better in reasoning and comprehension abilities. As a side observation, it was found that the school relied heavily on corporal punishment of the children, especially the younger ones.
7. **Action orientation** also improved with age. This aspect is best left to be tested in a more realistic setting than under such hypothetical story telling session where it was much easier to suggest action for another unrelated character.

8. There was no visible **gender discrimination** or related thought that was observed **within the school premises**.
9. The meaning and concept of **caste** was missing in most children as only the 3rd group claimed to know its meaning. Even here, most mixed up caste with religion and their sub-castes. Even though children did not perceive any difference with respect to caste, it was observed that in the second group, children from reserved category were weaker in communication, comprehension and reasoning.
10. Out of all children, only 1/3rd of children (falling into the 3rd group) knew the meaning of ***greed*** and considered it to be unacceptable.
11. In the 2nd group, girls out-performed boys in areas of *empathy*, reasoning and communication.

↵ **Back to Table of Contents**

7. Conclusion

The school chosen was an English medium private school. To the researchers' observation, the following relevant areas need attention: poor expression in English, weak working memory, poor comprehension, poor simple mental math, liberal use of corporal punishment to discipline children, lack of creative thinking and fear. Piaget's cognitive development theories indicate that the process of learning involves 'disequilibrium', and Kohlberg's studies have confirmed that the 'disequilibrium'[1] is needed for development of values too (2009, McLeod). It is obvious that there are two prerequisites to learning in this way: inquisitiveness and reasoning abilities; absence of either will affect the course of learning. In this study, most children were found to be weak in both. In addition, surprisingly, many children even in the 2nd group were unable to solve the simple word problem in the last story. These points are being brought up because they could correlate with the quality of children's learning. This raises questions about utilising their true potential as well as the quality of the lessons learnt. The observations and findings also raise a question: are children of this school spending

[1] Disequilibrium is a state of mind that results from encountering new information (that does not 'fit-in' with the rest of knowledge base) and causing the brain to ponder as a result of noticing the new thing and then either making a place for it in the mind.

their early years in fear of punishment? With the practice of corporal punishment in primary wing, assuming that punishment has affected their learning may not be so far from reality.

The school chosen for the study imparts value education in a classroom setting, like most other subjects. The possibility to engage in meaningful discussion over values and debate was found to be missing, as per few students. This also corroborates with the limited ability of most children to reason and imagine in most children. Ability to imagine underlies development of *empathy*, which further underlies responsible actions. If children are not taught to empathise in school, there is no guarantee if they would learn it elsewhere. Parenting styles have been associated with development of *empathy* by Psychologists such as Hoffman (McLeod) but leaving the task of value education to parents, who may or may not adopt the 'best practices', may adversely affect the collective values we share as a society. Lack of complete *empathy*, as found in this study, would make children poor perceivers and judges of acts such as *cheating*, *trust* and their effects. Further, it was surprising to find only few children who knew the concept of *greed* even in higher age group. *Greed* or lack of contentment is at the core of corruption in our society. When exactly will these children learn about this dreadful vice?

At this juncture, it may be worthwhile to raise questions on time spent and method adopted for inculcating values: one period each week in a classroom setting. The kind of individuals we see in the real world is an outcome of the efforts we put in educating our children. The format and the dissemination could be questionable too! We will not know unless we attempt to find out. Children learn a lot from general practices around them and when practice contradicts classroom lessons, confusion is bound to set in and the decision is then left to the discretion of that confused little mind. This aspect of curriculum design and dissemination, however important, was not within the realms of the current study.

This study has highlighted some important concerns for the moral development of the children in the areas of reasoning, creative thinking, imagination, expression, missing concepts of caste and *greed*. It must be noted that this school might be an above average school in terms of quality of education and facilities as well as gender equality, caste equality and concept of fairness. Therefore, even if statistically not

representative, the proportion of 'weak performers' in this study was far from massive. At the same time, the proportion was not too small to ignore either.

8. Issues And Concerns for Future Research

1. Firstly, the researcher set out to explore the thoughts with respect to values but ended up with several other related aspects that may have an effect on acquiring the stated values. Most children were unable to express their thoughts or reasons behind their decisions. This made it hard to find out what their actual thoughts were. Perhaps, in future, connections could be explored between comprehension, family background, parenting styles, communication/expression skill, reasoning abilities, and the various value parameters.
2. Based on the above findings, value parameters must be defined clearly for measurement. For example, due to lack of proper definition, it was challenging to determining the degree of empathy exhibited by a child. I have used terms such as 'deep empathy' or 'little empathy' based on a child's ability to relate with the number of characters and their emptions. But these terminologies need refining for future.
3. It is worth probing if the same children respond the same way to the similar questions if asked later on? Reason being, sometimes post-interview reflections may lead to change in reasoning…after all this was moral dilemma we were testing them on. Dilemmas can precipitate varied responses depending upon the state of mind.
4. The same questionnaire could be used to test if children in small groups respond differently. If questioned in a small group of 3-4 children, each child thinks more competitively and tries to be more creative in reasoning. The consciousness from being the only one interviewed is removed in such a setting. However, the down side of this could be that one may influence the answer of another. It would be hard to tell why respondent said what he/she said unless it was original / unique.
5. The questions were based on hypothetical stories and their responses, as has been criticised earlier, may not be relevant in real life situations. To tackle this, perhaps games or simulations could be designed to make the test more realistic.

6. The questionnaire was rather lengthy but suitable for an in-depth qualitative research. In case of a quantitative study on this subject, the present method may need to be modified else it would be too cost intensive. It not only consumed an average of 1 hour per child but also needed skill and patience in telling the stories, ensuring that the stories were understood, probing for in-depth understanding and recording responses.
7. Finally, to get a wider and deeper picture on 'values', studies could be designed on similar lines to obtain data from adults, parents, teachers, youth etc.

↵ Back to Table of Contents Back to Finding and Analysis Back to Group-wise Analysis

9. Stories and Questions

Theme: *Integrity* (values studied were '*hard-work*', '*cheating*', '*trust*')

***Integrity* - Neutral**

Ashok is very good in studies and is popular too. All teachers and students adore him. Since he is the top scorer of the class, his class teacher asks him to check answer sheets of some students quite often. Ashok himself works very hard to get good marks but he gives high marks to his lazy friends. The teacher *trust*s Ashok and since everyone likes him, nobody complains. Every time Ashok gets papers to evaluate, he tries to help his friends without telling anyone.

> Questions: a) Is it alright to do what Ashok is doing? Why?; B) Should the teacher know about this?; C) Who should tell the teacher?; D) Should the students being helped by Ashok tell?; E) What should the teacher do upon finding out?; F) Should Ashok be punished? How?; G) Why is Ashok *cheating* the teacher? Where could he have learnt to cheat?

***Integrity*- Gender**

Arun,Saurabh and Sarika were given a painting assignment. Saurabh and Sarika always work hard to make their paintings by themselves. But Arun does not like to paint, so, he is very worried about this homework. Arun asks his friend to make the painting for him and buys him ice-cream for this favour. Sarika finds out that Arun is *cheating*. When she tells Arun to do his own work else she would complain to his mother and the teacher, Arun threatens her of hurting her if she told anyone. Sarika is confused because Arun is much stronger than her.

> Questions: A) What should Sarika do? Why?; B) If Sarika tells the teacher, what would the teacher do?; C) If she tells Arun's mother, what would Arun's mother do?; D) Why does he not do his own work?; E) Where did Arun learn to cheat and *lie*?; F) Should Arun be Punished? How?; G) If Arun is punished for his *cheating*, how would he feel?; H) If he is not punished, then how would he feel?; I) Why should he be told do his own work?; J) Should boys be punished differently than girls when found to be *cheating*?

***Integrity*- Caste**

Sunil is very good in acting and he loves to act on stage. When a school drama selection contest is announced, he works very hard for the selection. On the day of selection, many students participate and perform in front of each other and some teachers. Everyone loved Sunil's performance. However, the drama teacher selected Sudeep since she did not want a student from poor family to be in her drama. Sunil's poor father is a cleaner at the same school.

> Questions: A) If you were watching the selection process, what would you feel?; B) Should someone do something about it? Who and what?; C) What should Sunil do and why?; D) Should someone be punished here? Who, how and by whom?; E) Would you punish someone? Who?; F) Should caste or category of a child affect his or her selection in drama? What could be the caste of Sunil?; F) How would Sunil and his interest in acting be affected if not selected?; G) Whose fault is it that the teacher did not chose Sunil? How did the teacher get to be this way?; H) Does Sunil father has the power to do something for his son? What and how?

THEME: Pro-Social Behaviour (Values studied: '*Empathy*', '*lying*', 'action orientation')

Pro-Social Behaviour- Neutral

Anshu saved money from his pocket money to buy his brother, Monu, a gift for his birthday. He wrapped up a very nice toy and presented to his brother during the birthday party in front of all his friends. Monu opened the gift and quickly kept it aside saying, "That is not what I wanted. There is nothing new about this toy ". Anshu was so badly hurt by Monu's reaction that he ran inside and cried throughout the party, while Monu continued playing with his friends.

> Questions: A) Why did Anshu cry so much? ; B) Had Monu said to Anshu in private (not in front of friends), would Anshu have cried this much?; C) Should Monu do something? What?; D) Why was Monu so rude to Anshu?; E) Is it wrong to hurt other's feelings? Why? Why does Monu not know this?; F) Will Anshu and Monu still be friends?

Pro-Social Behaviour- Gender

There was only one swing at the park on which Raghav was swinging merrily. Aruna had been waiting for her turn for a long time but Raghav was enjoying swinging so much that he would not let go of the swing for Aruna. Aruna began crying and asked the teacher for help. The teacher was too busy with her work and she ignored Aruna's request. So Aruna went home in tears and Raghav continued swinging merrily.

> Questions: A) Who is at fault? Why?; B) Should someone be punished? How and why?; C) Do girls and boys get equal chance to play or boys play more? Why?; D) If Sunita was swinging in place of Raghav and Raghav was waiting endlessly, would the teacher have helped him?

Pro-Social Behaviour- Caste

Varun and Anil go to the same class. Anil looks like a boy from very poor family as his shirt is not always clean and his shoe soles are worn out. Varun comes from a rich family but still they are good friends. One day, Anil could not bring lunch and was shy to ask Varun for his help. So, he stole food from another student's bag. Varun caught Anil stealing. He is confused whether to complain to the teacher or let Anil eat because he is poor and hungry.

> Questions: A) Is Anil doing the right thing by stealing food? Why?; B) What should Varun do? If he should help, till when can he help Anil? ; C) When should he tell the teacher?; D) Can Varun's parents get involved in some way?; E) What would happen if he tells the teacher? How would Anil feel?; F) Is it never right to steal or one can steal under certain situations? What situations?; G) If Anil was not Varun's friend, should he have told the teacher immediately?

THEME: *Greed*

***Greed*- Neutral**

Navin belongs to a rich family and his parents buy him whatever he asks for. Navin also gets money to go to school by bus but he chose to walk mostly so that he can save 20 Rs everyday and buy goodies for himself later. When his mother asks, he always says he went by bus. One day, his Aunt sees him walking to school and tells his mother. When confronted, he lies because otherwise his mother will stop giving him the money.

> Questions: A) If Navin's parents give him everything he asks for, why does he *lie*?; B) What should the mother do? Should his mother believe Navin's aunt or Navin? Why?; C) Why is Navin *lying*?; D) Is Navin greedy? Is *greed* good?

***Greed*- Neutral**

Shweta's mother gives her 100 chocolates to distribute in her class for her birthday. She gives only 20 to her close friends and keeps the rest for herself.

> Questions: A) Is she greedy?; B) What should her mother do if she finds out? ; C) Can one be greedy sometimes? When?; D) When is *greed* good and when is it bad?; E) Why are some children greedy? Where do they learn?

Direct Questions

1. Who sits in the last row?
2. Who cleans the class? Who asks them to clean the class?
3. Where does everyone get water from? Are there different water outlets for different children?
4. Where do you drink water from?
5. Can you sit anywhere and with anyone?
6. Are there children from different castes in your class? What castes?
7. Is any caste bad? What do you feel for children form bad caste?
8. Is there any teacher who is partial towards students from good caste?
9. Where did you learn about good and bad castes?
10. Do you see a difference between poor and rich children? What?
11. Does someone ask you to NOT mingle with someone…who? Who asks you to?
12. How many schools have you changed so far? Why?

13. What do you like to do in school and what do you dislike doing here?
14. Does anything trouble or bother you in this school? What?
15. Do you ask questions in the class? If not, why?
16. Do you answer questions when you know the answer? If not, why?
17. What would you liked changed about your experience in school/s?

↵ Back to Table of Contents Back to Finding and Analysis Back to Group-wise Analysis

10. References

- Cardwell, M. and Flanagan, C. (2004). *Psychology A2 - The Complete Companion for AQA: The Complete Companion Guide for AQA*. Cheltenham (United Kingdom): Nelson Thornes
- Cherry, K. *Background and Key Concepts of Piaget's Theory: Stages of Cognitive Development*. URL: http://psychology.about.com/od/piagetstheory/a/keyconcepts.htm
- Driscoll, A. and Nagel, N.G. *Piaget's Stages of Cognitive Development*. URL: http://www.education.com/reference/article/piagets-stages-cognitive-development/
- Gomez-Tejedor, B.C and Montes, R.B. (1999). *Educate, Don't Punish: Awareness Campaign Against Corporal Punishment of Children in Fami*lie*s*. Save the Children.
- Heylighen, F., Joslyn, C. and Turchin, V. (2001). *Evolutionary Values*. Principia Cybernetica Web (Principia Cybernetica, Brussels), URL: http://pespmc1.vub.ac.be/EVOLVAL.html.
- Kohn, A (1997). *How Not to Teach Values*. Phi Delta Kappan
- McLeod, S. A. (2008). *Erik Erikson | Psychosocial Stages.* Retrieved from http://www.simplypsychology.org/Erik-Erikson.html
- McLeod, S. A. (2009). *Jean Piaget | Cognitive Theory.* Retrieved from http://www.simplypsychology.org/piaget.html
- McLeod, S. A. (2011). *Kohlberg - Moral Development.* Retrieved from http://www.simplypsychology.org/kohlberg.html
- Piaget, J. (1965). *The Moral Judgement of the Child*. Chicago, Illinois: Free Press
- Taina, K and Maatta, K.(2011). *Using children as research subjects: How to interview a child aged 5 to 7 years*. Educational Research and Reviews Vol. 6(1), pp. 87-93.
- The Science of Morality, an audio of discussions and interviews of neurologists and psychologists. URL: http://www.bbc.co.uk/radio/player/p00rdps3
- Willard, N. (1997). *Moral Development in Information Age*. Oregon. URL: http://tigger.uic.edu/~lnucci/MoralEd/articles/willard.html

----------Acknowledgements----------

We would like to thank the Principal, the Vice Principal, the Head Mistress, the teachers, the Peon, and the students who cooperated in this study by sparing their time and effort very generously.

(The name of the school is not being disclosed on purpose).